

ELEVEN

‘Good evening, Ma’am. Flight Cadet Gunjan Saxena reporting for lights-out parade state,’ I said after knocking on the cabin door exactly twice, as per the instructions of Preeti Lavale, the woman under officer (WUO). A WUO is an appointment given to one senior-term cadet of each squadron; they generally hold the responsibility of grooming the junior cadets for correct military bearing and for all things related to training. A cadet from flank* had to report to the WUO sharp at ten in the night for the lights-out report, which had to be prepared in a particular format. I was chosen to do it for my flank.

‘I can’t hear you,’ WUO Preeti Lavale said coldly from across the closed door even though I had been loud enough. ‘Be louder.’

I repeated the same line a little louder than the last.

‘I still can’t hear you,’ she replied. I screamed at the top of my voice this time.

‘Bend,’ she said as she opened the door and stood cross-armed against the side-jambs. Not knowing what I could have done wrong, I returned a questioning look. ‘You want to disobey, you tiny first-termer?’ she said angrily. ‘Bend!’ To bend always meant to get into a high-plank position, and I did as was asked. There was no way I could question her. Nobody questions a senior in the academy. ‘Next time make sure you are loud in your first attempt itself,’ she said plainly. ‘Now get up.’